

The Small Business AI Prompt Playbook

25 ready-to-use prompts for marketing, support, finance, hiring & sales

Copy. Paste. Fill in the brackets. Done.

How to use this playbook

Every prompt below works with any modern AI chat assistant (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, or similar). Replace anything in [BRACKETS] with your own details, then paste the whole prompt in. Each one includes a note on when it's actually worth using and a tip on how to adapt it to your business specifically — templates only work if you customize them.

A companion spreadsheet (AI-Ops-Tracker.xlsx) is included in your download — use it to log which prompts you use, how much time each one saves, and see a running ROI estimate.

What's inside

- Marketing & Content — 5 prompts
- Customer Service & Support — 5 prompts
- Finance & Operations — 5 prompts
- Hiring & HR — 5 prompts
- Sales & Outreach — 5 prompts

Marketing & Content

1. Weekly Social Content Batch

Act as a social media copywriter for [BUSINESS NAME], a [BUSINESS TYPE] that helps [TARGET CUSTOMER] with [MAIN BENEFIT]. Take this single topic: "[TOPIC]". Turn it into 5 posts, one each for Instagram, LinkedIn, Facebook, X/Twitter, and an email teaser. Match tone to each platform, keep each under the platform's practical length, and end every post with one clear call to action: [DESIRED ACTION, e.g. 'book a call', 'reply to this email'].

When to use it: Monday planning session — turn one idea into a week of content in one pass.

Pro tip: Paste 2-3 examples of your best-performing past posts before the prompt so the tone matches your actual voice, not a generic one.

2. Customer Testimonial Rewriter

Here is a raw customer quote or review: "[PASTE QUOTE]". Rewrite it into three formats: (1) a punchy one-line quote for a website hero section, (2) a short LinkedIn post from the business's perspective thanking the customer and adding context, (3) a 2-sentence blurb for an email newsletter. Keep the customer's actual meaning intact — do not invent details they didn't say.

When to use it: Any time you get a good review, DM, or email compliment.

Pro tip: Always get the customer's OK before publishing their words publicly, even paraphrased.

3. Local SEO Blog Outline

I run a [BUSINESS TYPE] in [CITY/REGION]. Write a blog post outline targeting the search term "[SEARCH TERM, e.g. best plumber in Austin]". Include: a title under 60 characters with the keyword near the front, a meta description under 155 characters, 5-6 H2 section headers that answer real questions a searcher would have, and one FAQ section with 3 question/answer pairs suitable for featured snippets.

When to use it: Building organic search traffic without paying for ads.

Pro tip: Search the term yourself first and note what's ranking — ask the model to outline something more specific/useful than the top 3 results.

4. Ad Copy A/B Variants

Write 5 ad copy variants for [PRODUCT/SERVICE], each testing a different angle: (1) leads with the pain point it solves, (2) leads with the core benefit, (3) leads with urgency/scarcity, (4) leads with social proof or a stat, (5) leads with curiosity. Each variant: one headline (under 40 characters) and one body line (under 90 characters), written for [PLATFORM, e.g. Meta/Google].

When to use it: Before launching or refreshing a paid ad campaign.

Pro tip: Run all 5 for at least a few hundred impressions each before picking a winner — don't judge on gut feel alone.

5. Email Newsletter From Bullet Points

Turn these rough notes into a newsletter email: [PASTE BULLET NOTES]. Structure: a subject line under 50 characters, a one-line preview text, a friendly opening line, 3-4 short sections with subheads, and a single clear call to action at the end. Keep the tone conversational, like a person wrote it, not corporate.

When to use it: Turning 10 minutes of scribbled notes into something ready to send.

Pro tip: Read it out loud before sending — if a sentence doesn't sound like something you'd say, cut it.

Customer Service & Support

1. Difficult Email Response Drafter

A customer sent this message: "[PASTE CUSTOMER MESSAGE]". Our situation/policy is: [EXPLAIN CONSTRAINTS, e.g. 'we can't refund after 30 days but can offer store credit']. Draft a reply that acknowledges their frustration specifically (not generically), explains the situation plainly without being defensive, and offers the best resolution we can actually give. Keep it under 150 words.

When to use it: Any time a customer email needs a careful, de-escalating response.

Pro tip: Never send the first draft unread — always personalize at least the opening line yourself.

2. FAQ Generator From Support Tickets

Here are the last [N] questions customers have asked us: [PASTE LIST]. Group them into themes, then write a clean FAQ page: one clear question per entry (rewritten in the customer's likely words) and a concise, complete answer for each. Flag any question you don't have enough information to answer confidently.

When to use it: Quarterly, or whenever support volume on the same topics is climbing.

Pro tip: Export tickets from your helpdesk as plain text first — the more real examples you paste in, the better the grouping.

3. Refund/Complaint Policy Explainer

Here is our internal policy, written informally: [PASTE POLICY NOTES]. Rewrite it as a customer-facing policy page: plain language, no legal jargon unless required, organized with short headers, and a tone that reads as fair rather than defensive. Include a short 'if something's wrong, here's what to do' section at the top.

When to use it: Publishing or updating a returns/refunds/complaints page.

Pro tip: Have an actual customer (or a friend who's never seen the policy) read it back — if they'd still be confused, revise.

4. Support Ticket Triage & Tagging

Classify each of these support messages into exactly one category from this list: [YOUR CATEGORIES, e.g. Billing, Bug Report, How-To, Refund Request, Other]. Also assign urgency (Low/Medium/High) based on language suggesting churn risk, safety issues, or blocked usage. Return as a table: message excerpt, category, urgency, one-line reason. Messages: [PASTE MESSAGES]

When to use it: Daily/weekly triage when ticket volume is too high to read one by one.

Pro tip: This is the one prompt in this pack worth automating via an API call instead of copy-pasting — ask me if you want that built.

5. Review Response Generator

Here is a customer review: "[PASTE REVIEW]" ([star rating]). Draft a public response in our brand voice: [DESCRIBE VOICE, e.g. warm, direct, a little playful]. Thank them specifically for something they mentioned, address any complaint honestly without over-apologizing, and if relevant invite them to follow up privately. Under 80 words.

When to use it: Responding to Google/Yelp/App Store reviews, especially negative ones.

Pro tip: Respond to negative reviews within 24-48 hours — speed reads as care, even before they read the content.

Finance & Operations

1. Expense Categorization Assistant

Here is a list of raw transactions (date, description, amount): [PASTE LIST]. Categorize each into one of: [YOUR CATEGORIES, e.g. Rent, Payroll, Software, Marketing, Supplies, Travel, Other]. Flag any transaction where the category is ambiguous instead of guessing. Return as a table plus a one-line total per category at the end.

When to use it: Monthly bookkeeping cleanup before it goes to your accountant.

Pro tip: Always have your accountant/bookkeeper verify categorization for tax purposes — this speeds up prep, it doesn't replace review.

2. Simple Cash Flow Narrative

Here are this month's numbers: revenue [\$X], expenses [\$Y] broken down as [BREAKDOWN], starting cash [\$Z]. Write a plain-English, 4-6 sentence summary of how the business is doing this month, suitable for a co-founder or investor update. No jargon, no spin — if something is concerning, say so plainly and note what's being done about it.

When to use it: Monthly investor/partner updates, or just to keep yourself honest about the numbers.

Pro tip: Feed it 2-3 months of history at once so it can note trends ('expenses up 12% vs last month'), not just a single snapshot.

3. Vendor Contract Summary

Here is a vendor contract: [PASTE OR DESCRIBE KEY SECTIONS]. Summarize: (1) price and payment terms, (2) contract length and renewal/cancellation terms including any auto-renewal notice deadline, (3) any exclusivity or non-compete clauses, (4) anything unusual or risky compared to standard vendor contracts. Flag anything I should have a lawyer look at rather than deciding on my own.

When to use it: Before signing, or when auditing existing vendor contracts for renewal traps.

Pro tip: This produces a reading guide, not legal advice — always have an actual lawyer review anything with real financial exposure.

4. SOP Writer From a Verbal Process

Here's how we currently do [PROCESS NAME], described roughly: [DESCRIBE THE STEPS AS YOU'D EXPLAIN THEM OUT LOUD]. Turn this into a numbered standard operating procedure a new employee could follow without asking questions. Call out any tools/logins needed at each step, and note any step where a judgment call is required instead of a fixed rule.

When to use it: Any time you catch yourself explaining the same process verbally more than twice.

Pro tip: Record yourself explaining the process out loud (voice memo), transcribe it, and paste that in — it captures details a tidy summary would drop.

5. Meeting Notes to Action Items

Here are raw notes from today's meeting: [PASTE NOTES]. Extract a clean action item list: each item as 'Owner — Action — Due date (if mentioned, else "unassigned")'. Then write a 3-sentence summary of the key decisions made, separate from the action items.

When to use it: Immediately after any meeting, before details fade.

Pro tip: Paste notes within the hour — quality drops fast once you're trying to recall what a shorthand note meant.

Hiring & HR

1. Job Description Generator

We need to hire a [ROLE]. Here's a rough list of what they'd actually do day to day: [PASTE ROUGH RESPONSIBILITIES]. Write a job description with: a short compelling intro about the role's impact, 5-7 responsibilities, 4-5 requirements split into 'must have' and 'nice to have', and a one-line note on compensation range placeholder. Review the language for anything that could unintentionally discourage qualified candidates (overly aggressive requirements lists, gendered language, etc.) and flag it.

When to use it: Opening a new role or refreshing a stale job post that isn't attracting candidates.

Pro tip: Post the 'must have' list separately from 'nice to have' in the actual listing — bundling them scares off good candidates who don't check every box.

2. Interview Question Set Builder

We're interviewing for [ROLE]. The most important things this person needs to be good at are: [LIST 3-4 CORE SKILLS/TRAITS]. Generate 8 interview questions that actually test for these (behavioral and situational, not just 'tell me about a time'). For each question, note briefly what a strong answer sounds like versus a weak one.

When to use it: Prepping for interviews, especially for a role you haven't hired for before.

Pro tip: Ask every candidate for a role the same core 3-4 questions so you can actually compare answers apples-to-apples.

3. Candidate Screening Rubric

Here is the job description for [ROLE]: [PASTE OR SUMMARIZE]. Build a scoring rubric with 5 criteria drawn directly from the requirements, each scored 1-4 with a one-line description of what a 1 vs a 4 looks like. Add a final 'red flags to watch for' section specific to this role.

When to use it: Before reviewing resumes/doing screening calls for a batch of candidates.

Pro tip: Fill out the rubric right after each call while it's fresh — scoring from memory a day later reintroduces bias.

4. Onboarding Checklist Generator

We just hired a [ROLE]. Build a first-30-days onboarding checklist broken into Week 1, Week 2, Weeks 3-4. Include account/tool setup, who they should meet and why, what they should be able to do independently by day 30, and one check-in question for their manager to ask at each week's end.

When to use it: Whenever a new hire starts — even a rough checklist beats none.

Pro tip: Ask the last person hired into a similar role what was missing from their onboarding, and fold that in.

5. Performance Review Draft Assistant

Here are my rough notes on [EMPLOYEE]'s performance this period: [PASTE NOTES, INCLUDING BOTH STRENGTHS AND CONCERNS]. Draft a performance review structured as: key strengths (specific, not generic praise), areas to develop (framed constructively, tied to specific examples), and 2-3 concrete goals for next period. Keep it honest — do not soften real concerns into vague language.

When to use it: Prepping for a formal review cycle.

Pro tip: Never let the draft replace the conversation — use it as prep so the actual discussion is clearer, not as something you just hand over.

Sales & Outreach

1. Cold Outreach Email Personalizer

Here's public information about a prospect: [PASTE LINKEDIN BIO / COMPANY NEWS / RECENT POST]. We sell [PRODUCT/SERVICE] which helps companies like theirs with [SPECIFIC BENEFIT]. Write a cold email: a personalized opening line referencing something specific and true about them (not generic flattery), 2 sentences connecting their likely situation to our benefit, and one low-friction call to action. Under 100 words total.

When to use it: Any outbound prospecting, especially for higher-value targets worth the extra 5 minutes of research.

Pro tip: If you can't find one genuinely specific detail about the prospect, don't fake one — send a shorter, honest, non-personalized version instead.

2. Objection Handling Script Builder

Prospects for [PRODUCT/SERVICE] commonly say: [LIST 3-5 REAL OBJECTIONS YOU HEAR]. For each objection, write a response that acknowledges the concern honestly (don't dismiss it), reframes with a relevant fact or example, and ends with a question that moves the conversation forward rather than a hard pitch.

When to use it: Sales team training, or prepping yourself before a call with a known-skeptical prospect.

Pro tip: Update this quarterly — the objections that matter shift as your market and pricing change.

3. Proposal/Quote Summary Writer

Here is our pricing/scope for this deal: [PASTE LINE ITEMS AND PRICES]. Write a one-page client-facing summary: what's included, what it costs (clearly broken down), what happens next (timeline/process), and a short paragraph reminding them of the specific problem this solves for them based on our earlier conversation: [SUMMARIZE THEIR STATED NEED].

When to use it: Sending a formal quote or proposal after a sales conversation.

Pro tip: Always tie the summary back to their specific stated problem — generic proposals read as templated and lose deals.

4. Follow-Up Sequence Generator

We had a sales call with a prospect about [PRODUCT/SERVICE]. They said their main interest was [THEIR STATED INTEREST] and their main hesitation was [THEIR STATED CONCERN]. Write a 4-email follow-up sequence spaced over 2 weeks: email 1 (recap + next step), email 2 (address their specific hesitation with proof/example), email 3 (share a relevant case study or resource), email 4 (direct, low-pressure check-in). Keep each under 120 words.

When to use it: Right after any sales call that doesn't close immediately.

Pro tip: Set actual calendar reminders for each send date — sequences only work if they're not forgotten after email 1.

5. Win/Loss Call Debrief Analyzer

Here are notes from a debrief on a deal we [WON/LOST]: [PASTE NOTES]. Summarize: the main factor that decided the outcome, 2-3 contributing factors, and one specific, actionable change to try on the next similar deal. Avoid vague takeaways like 'be more persuasive' — make it concrete.

When to use it: After any deal closes, win or lose, while details are still fresh.

Pro tip: Do this for wins too, not just losses — you learn what to repeat, not just what to avoid.

Want this tailored to your business?

These prompts are deliberately generic templates so they work across industries. If you want a custom set built specifically around your business, your voice, and your actual recurring tasks, reach out — contact details are on the product page you downloaded this from.

More From Ledger & Loop Digital

If this playbook was useful, three more toolkits solve specific problems these general prompts don't. Look for these on the same store page you downloaded this from.

AI Prompt Playbook Vol. 2: Systems & Automation — \$17

25 more prompts, but for building repeatable systems instead of one-off tasks: AI systems, customer lifecycle automation, competitive intelligence, ops reporting, and delegation. Plus a recurring-workflow ROI tracker.

The Freelancer Quarterly Tax & Expense Tracker (2026 Edition) — \$19

2026 quarterly deadlines, a self-employment tax calculator with a worked example, all 17 Schedule C expense categories, and a live tax-estimator spreadsheet.

The Freelancer Invoice & Late-Payment Toolkit — \$17

A ready-to-copy 4-stage reminder email sequence, how to choose payment terms and set an enforceable late fee, and a spreadsheet that auto-flags overdue invoices.